

Incremental AI Filmmaking: From a 2-Sentence Story to a 30s Commercial

Start with a tiny narrative seed and pile on Character Face Lock, Empty Sets, Storyboards, Motion, Dialogue & Scenebuilder.



00 · Story Seed

- 2-Sentence Logline
- 3-Act Micro-Arc
- 2 Characters Max
- 2 Locations + 1 Prop
- Cold -> Warm Shift

[Stage 0 Lab ↗](#)



01 · Face Lock

- 35-Word Anchor Block
- Neutral 5600K Portrait
- 4-Angle Turnaround
- Character Ingredients
- Zero Identity Drift

[Stage 1 Lab ↗](#)



02-03 · Set & Board

- Empty Location Plates
- Hero Product Macro
- 6-Shot Storyboard
- Start/End Frame Pairs
- Continuity Bridges

[Stage 2-3 Lab ↗](#)



04 · Camera & Motion

- Ingredients to Video
- Frames to Video
- 7-Part Prompt Formula
- Anamorphic & Macro
- Veo 3.1 Physics

[Stage 4 Lab ↗](#)



05-06 · Talk & Edit

- 180° Eyeline Rule
- Shot-Reverse-Shot
- Native Lip-Sync + TTS
- Scenebuilder Extend
- Jump To & J/L Cuts

[Prompt Library ↗](#)



[Full Workshop Repo, Facilitator Script & Copy-Paste Prompts: https://github.com/AllInVaders/google-flow-storytelling-workshop](https://github.com/AllInVaders/google-flow-storytelling-workshop)

Why Single-Prompt Video Fails vs. The Layer-Cake Production Pipeline

Separating story, character identity, empty sets, and camera physics eliminates character drift across every platform.



The 'One Giant Prompt' Trap (Point A)

- Typing 'Make a 30s coffee commercial' into a single prompt box.
- Protagonist's face, glasses, and jacket mutate in every clip.
- Background room geometry and product logos hallucinate.
- Two speaking characters look away from each other.



The Incremental Layer-Cake Method (Point B)

- Lock 2-sentence story -> Lock faces -> Lock empty sets -> Storyboard.
- Combine up to 3 pinned Ingredients per shot in Google Flow.
- Use Start/End Frames for deterministic product transitions.
- Direct 2-character conversations using the 180-Degree Rule.

Incremental Layering Equation (Google Flow + Any GenMedia Platform)

[Facilitator Playbook ↗](#)

Layer 0 (Story Seed)	-> 2 sentences + 3-Act lighting contrast (Cold Cyan -> Warm Amber -> Sunrise)
Layer 1 (Identity Lock)	-> 35-word verbatim Identity Anchor Block + Neutral 5600K Portrait / 4-Angle Sheet
Layer 2 (Stage & Prop)	-> Empty Location Plates ([SCENE_STUDIO], [SCENE_CAFE]) + Hero Product ([PROP_CUP])
Layer 3 (Visual Storyboard)	-> 6 Composited Keyframes (Start & End Frame pairs before rendering video)
Layer 4-6 (Motion + Audio)	-> Ingredients-to-Video + Frames-to-Video + 180° Shot-Reverse-Shot Dialogue + Scenebuilder



Rule #1 of AI Filmmaking: Never invent your character, your room, and your camera move for the first time in the same video prompt.

Mapping the Workshop to Google Flow & Universal GenMedia Platforms

Every workshop exercise runs natively in Google Flow while mapping 1:1 to Vertex AI, AI Studio, Runway, Luma, and Midjourney.



1. Ingredients Panel (Asset & Identity Vault)

- Google Flow: Create or upload Character, Scene, and Object Ingredients (Nano Banana Pro / Imagen).
- Cross-Platform: Generate a 4-Angle Character Turnaround Sheet + Empty Location Plates as reference images.

[Open Google Flow ↗](#)



2. Dual Video Engines (Ingredients vs. Frames)

- Ingredients to Video: Blend up to 3 references (Character + Set + Prop) with Veo 3.1 camera prompts.
- Frames to Video: Lock exact First Frame + Last Frame to interpolate smooth macro transitions.

[Google AI Studio ↗](#)



3. Scenebuilder Timeline (Extend, Jump To & Audio)

- Extend: Lengthen a clip seamlessly from its final frames.
- Jump To: Bridge a character into a new scene/angle.
- Audio: Veo 3.1 native lip-sync + Gemini 3.8 Flash TTS + Lyria 3 score.

[Cross-Platform Matrix ↗](#)



Model Stack: [gemini-3.8-flash \(Story\)](#) · [gemini-3-pro-image \(Nano Banana Pro\)](#) · [veo-3.1](#) · [gemini-3.8-flash-tts](#) · [lyria-3](#)

Start with a 2-Sentence Story Seed & Expand to a 3-Act Micro-Arc

Constrain the commercial to 30 seconds, 2 characters, 2 contrasting locations, and 1 hero prop before generating visuals.



The 2-Sentence Seed ('Solis — The 6:00 AM Spark')

"At 5:45 AM in a rainy city, an exhausted architect staring at a blank blueprint steps into a glowing corner café. One shared laugh and a warm terracotta cup of espresso reignite her creative spark."



3-Act Visual & Lighting Arc (30 Seconds)

- Act I (0–8s): Cold Cyan Rain — Maya stuck at her studio desk.
- Act II (8–22s): Warm Amber Glow — Leo slides the Solis cup across the counter; a 2-line conversation.
- Act III (22–30s): Golden Sunrise — Maya sketches the bridge arch.

Copy-Paste Prompt 0.1 — Expand Story Seed (Run in Flow Agent / gemini-3.8-flash)

[Copy Prompt 0.1 ↗](#)

Act as a Commercial Film Director. I have a two-sentence story seed for a 30-second brand commercial for 'Solis Artisan Coffee':
"At 5:45 AM in a rainy city, an exhausted architect staring at a blank blueprint steps into a glowing corner café.
One shared laugh and a warm terracotta cup of espresso reignite her creative spark."
Expand this seed into a tight 3-Act Micro-Story (Act I: The Creative Block, Act II: The Warm Encounter, Act III: The Spark Reignited).
Keep it grounded in 2 characters (Maya, architect; Leo, barista), 2 locations, and 1 hero prop (matte terracotta Solis cup).



Color & Mood Arc: Cold Cyan Pre-Dawn Rain (Problem) -> Warm Amber Edison Café (Connection) -> Golden Sunrise (Transformation).

The 3-Pillar System for Zero Face Drift Across Shots & Platforms

Combine a verbatim 35-word Identity Anchor Block, a neutral 5600K studio portrait, and a 4-Angle Turnaround Sheet.



Pillar 1 · The 35-Word Identity Anchor Block

- Never write 'a young woman' in Shot 1 and 'Maya' in Shot 2.
- Lock 5 traits: Age/Heritage + Skin micro-feature (freckles/crinkles) + Hair clip + Eyewear + Outer/Inner Wardrobe.
- Paste verbatim into every shot.

[Anchor Templates ↗](#)



Pillar 2 · Neutral 5600K Character Ingredient

- Generate your master portrait on a clean neutral grey backdrop with soft 5600K studio light (85mm, f/2.0).
- Avoid colored neon light in reference portraits so lighting adapts cleanly to any scene.

[Stage 1 Guide ↗](#)



Pillar 3 · The 4-Angle Turnaround Sheet

- Prompt Nano Banana Pro (gemini-3-pro-image) for a 4-panel sheet in one 16:9 frame: Front, 45°, Profile, Smiling Close-Up.
- Crop panels to feed angle-matched references on any platform!

[Turnaround Prompt ↗](#)



Pro Tip: Distinct accessories (round tortoiseshell glasses + ochre knit cardigan) act as high-weight visual anchors for video models.

Live Lab #1: Generating Locked Character Portraits & Turnaround Sheets

Run these prompts in Google Flow's Ingredients Panel (or Nano Banana Pro / gemini-3-pro-image) and pin both characters.



Protagonist Anchor: `[CHAR\_MAYA]` (Architect)

"Maya, a 29-year-old Latina architect with warm olive skin, subtle freckles across the nose, expressive dark brown eyes, shoulder-length wavy raven hair tied in a loose low clip, wearing an oversized ochre knit cardigan over a white crew-neck tee and round tortoiseshell glasses."



Co-Star Anchor: `[CHAR\_LEO]` (Barista)

"Leo, a 45-year-old artisanal barista with a neatly trimmed salt-and-pepper beard, warm crinkles around hazel eyes, wearing a charcoal linen apron over a rolled-sleeve chambray shirt. Neutral studio backdrop, soft warm key light, 85mm prime lens."

Copy-Paste Prompt 1.2 – 4-Angle Face Consistency Sheet (‘gemini-3-pro-image’)

[Open Web Prompt Deck ↗](#)

A 4-panel character reference sheet on a clean neutral grey background showing the exact same woman in four views:

(1) Front view neutral expression, (2) 45-degree three-quarter view with a tired sigh,
(3) Side profile looking down thoughtfully, (4) Front close-up with a warm, genuine smile.

Subject: Maya, a 29-year-old Latina architect with warm olive skin, subtle freckles across the nose, expressive dark brown eyes, shoulder-length wavy raven hair tied in a loose low clip, wearing an oversized ochre knit cardigan and round tortoiseshell glasses.



In Google Flow: Open 'Ingredients' -> Create Ingredient -> Generate Maya & Leo -> Pin both to your project asset library.

Build the Stage Before Calling the Actors: Empty Plates & Product Lock

Generate actor-free Location Ingredients and a macro Product Ingredient so room layouts and brand logos stay rock-solid.



Scene Ingredient A `[SCENE\_STUDIO]` (Act I)

- Minimalist architect's loft desk at 5:45 AM before dawn.
- Tall rain-streaked industrial window + cool cyan-blue drafting lamp.
- Explicitly prompt: 'Empty chair, no people' so the plate is clean.

[Prompt 2.1 ↗](#)



Scene Ingredient B `[SCENE\_CAFE]` (Act II)

- Cozy wood-paneled artisan espresso bar at dawn.
- Warm amber Edison bulbs, brass espresso machine, reclaimed oak counter.
- Fogged rainy window in background for visual contrast.

[Prompt 2.2 ↗](#)



Object Ingredient `[PROP\_CUP]` (Hero Product)

- Handcrafted matte terracotta ceramic cup + saucer.
- Minimalist gold embossed sun emblem and clean word 'SOLIS'.
- Generated in Nano Banana Pro (gemini-3-pro-image) for exact typography.

[Prompt 2.3 ↗](#)



Why 'Empty Chair, No People'? If a location plate already contains a random person, the video model will fight your Character Ingredient.

Live Lab #2: Generating `[SCENE\_STUDIO]`, `[SCENE\_CAFE]` & `[PROP\_CUP]`

Create and pin these 3 visual assets so your Ingredients library holds all 5 core building blocks of the commercial.



Prompt 2.1 — Cold Rainy Studio (`[SCENE\_STUDIO]`)

"Wide establishing interior shot of a minimalist architect's loft desk by a tall rain-streaked industrial window at 5:45 AM before dawn. Empty chair, no people. A drafting lamp casts a cool cyan-blue pool of light over an unrolled blank blueprint and scale ruler. 35mm anamorphic lens."



Prompt 2.2 — Warm Corner Café (`[SCENE\_CAFE]`)

"Medium-wide interior shot of a cozy, wood-paneled artisan espresso bar at dawn. Empty frame with no people. Warm amber Edison bulbs and a polished brass espresso machine gleam with gentle steam rising. Rain outside fogged window, reclaimed oak counter in foreground."

Copy-Paste Prompt 2.3 — Hero Product Ingredient (`[PROP\_CUP]` in Nano Banana Pro)

[Copy Stage 2 Prompts ↗](#)

Macro studio product photograph of a handcrafted matte terracotta ceramic cappuccino cup resting on a matching terracotta saucer. A minimalist gold embossed sun emblem and the word "SOLIS" are printed cleanly on the front of the cup. Rich velvety hazelnut crema with delicate rosetta latte art on top, a wisp of steam rising. Soft warm rim lighting, neutral dark studio background, 100mm macro lens.



Checkpoint: You now have 5 pinned Ingredients — [CHAR_MAYA], [CHAR_LEO], [SCENE_STUDIO], [SCENE_CAFE], and [PROP_CUP].

The 6-Shot Commercial Storyboard & Ingredient Combination Matrix

Lock framing, lighting transitions, and Start/End keyframe pairs in still images before spending video compute.



Shots 1 & 2 · Act I -> Act II Threshold (0–10s)

- Shot 1: [CHAR_MAYA] + [SCENE_STUDIO] — Medium close-up at 5:45 AM; cold cyan rain reflects on her glasses.
- Shot 2: [CHAR_MAYA] + [SCENE_CAFE] — Tracking shot stepping out of blue rain into warm amber café glow.

[Keyframes 3.1 & 3.2 ↗](#)



Shot 3 · Hero Product Start -> End Pair (10–15s)

- First Frame: Espresso pouring in dual streams into the matte terracotta SOLIS cup.
- Last Frame: Leo's hand sliding the steaming SOLIS cup across the oak counter toward the camera.

[Keyframe Pair 3.3 ↗](#)



Shots 4 & 5 · Two-Character Conversation (15–25s)

- Shot 4 (OTS): [CHAR_LEO] on right looking screen-left over Maya's shoulder.
- Shot 5 (Reverse): [CHAR_MAYA] on left looking screen-right, holding the SOLIS cup and smiling.

[Keyframes 3.4 & 3.5 ↗](#)



Shot 6 · Act III Spark Reignited Finale (25–30s)

- First Frame: Golden sunrise hits the studio desk as Maya sets the SOLIS cup beside the blank blueprint.
- Last Frame: High-angle over shoulder as her charcoal pencil sweeps a bold bridge arch.

[Keyframe Pair 3.6 ↗](#)



Storyboarding Rule: Every shot combines at most 3 Ingredients (Character + Location + Prop) for maximum model adherence.

Live Lab #3: Generating Storyboard Stills Before Animating Video

Combine Character + Scene references into still frames to verify composition and prepare First/Last frames for Veo 3.1.



Keyframe 3.1 — Shot 1 Start Still (Maya + Studio)

Attach [CHAR_MAYA] + [SCENE_STUDIO]: Maya sits at the rain-streaked architect's desk at 5:45 AM resting her chin on her hand, staring at the blank blueprint. Cool cyan window light reflects on her tortoiseshell glasses.



Keyframe 3.3 — Shot 3 Start & End Frame Pair

- First Frame: Macro shot under brass portafilter pouring espresso into the terracotta SOLIS cup.
- Last Frame: Leo's hand sliding the steaming SOLIS cup across the reclaimed oak counter into foreground close-up.

Copy-Paste Prompt 3.1 — Composited Storyboard Keyframe (Multi-Image Reference)

[All 6 Keyframe Prompts ↗](#)

Using the character reference for Maya and the studio location reference:
Medium close-up cinema still of Maya, a 29-year-old Latina architect with warm olive skin, subtle freckles, wavy raven hair in a low clip, round tortoiseshell glasses, and an ochre knit cardigan, sitting at the rain-streaked architect's desk at 5:45 AM. She rests her chin on her hand, staring at the blank blueprint with a tired expression. Cool cyan-blue pre-dawn window light reflects on her glasses. 35mm anamorphic lens.



Why generate Start & End frames for Shot 3? Because 'Frames to Video' guarantees the SOLIS logo lands sharply in the final frame!

Mastering 'Ingredients to Video', 'Frames to Video' & Camera Syntax

Once visuals are anchored in references, dedicate your video prompt to camera movement, physical action, and sound.



Mode A · Ingredients to Video (Up to 3 Refs)

- Upload [CHAR_MAYA] + [SCENE_STUDIO] + [PROP_CUP].
- Best for natural acting, subtle facial expressions, and continuous camera moves (Shots 1, 2, 4, 5).
- Always include the 35-word Identity Anchor Block.

[Open Google Flow ↗](#)



Mode B · Frames to Video (First + Last)

- Upload First Frame + Last Frame.
- Veo 3.1 interpolates camera travel, lighting shift, and fluid physics between the two keyframes.
- Best for product reveals & match cuts (Shots 3 & 6).

[Stage 4 Guide ↗](#)



The 7-Part Cinematic Video Prompt Formula

1. Shot Size & Angle
2. Camera Movement (dolly-in, tracking)
3. Identity Anchor + Action
4. Scene & Lighting
5. Lens (35mm anamorphic)
6. Dialogue in 'quotes'
7. Audio / SFX cues

[Prompt Formula ↗](#)



Camera Vocabulary That Works Best in Veo 3.1: 'Slow smooth dolly-in', 'Lateral tracking shot', 'Over-the-shoulder', 'Macro push-in'.

Live Lab #4: Running 'Ingredients to Video' & 'Frames to Video'

Generate the opening creative block (Shot 1), the café entrance (Shot 2), and the macro espresso slide (Shot 3).



Shot 1 Setup — Ingredients to Video (`Veo 3.1`)

- Attach Ingredients: [CHAR_MAYA] + [SCENE_STUDIO]
- Camera: Slow, smooth dolly-in toward medium close-up.
- Action: Maya exhales a quiet sigh, taps her wooden pencil twice on the blank blueprint, glances at the rain.



Shot 3 Setup — Frames to Video (`First` -> `Last`)

- First Frame: Espresso pouring into SOLIS cup.
- Last Frame: Leo's hand sliding SOLIS cup to foreground.
- Camera: 100mm macro tracking shot, 60fps slow-motion feel with rising golden steam.

Copy-Paste Prompt 4.1 — Shot 1 Video ('Ingredients to Video' with Native Audio)

[Copy Shots 1-3 Prompts ↗](#)

Slow, smooth dolly-in toward a medium close-up of Maya, a 29-year-old Latina architect with warm olive skin, subtle freckles, wavy raven hair in a low clip, round tortoiseshell glasses, and an ochre knit cardigan, sitting at her drafting table by a rain-streaked window at 5:45 AM. She exhales a quiet sigh, taps her wooden pencil twice against the blank blueprint, and glances out at the rain. Cold cyan streetlamp reflections glide across her glasses. 35mm anamorphic lens.

Audio: Soft rhythmic rain pattering against window glass, distant thunder, two crisp wooden pencil taps, and a quiet sigh.



Notice the 'Audio:' cue at the end: Veo 3.1 natively synthesizes synchronized rain, pencil taps, and espresso extraction SFX.

How to Direct Believable Two-Character Conversations in AI Video

Combine the 180-Degree Eyeline Rule, single-quoted dialogue prompts, Gemini 3.8 Flash TTS, and Lyria 3 music.



1. The 180° Eyeline Rule (Shot-Reverse-Shot)

- To make two clips look like a real conversation, lock opposite screen directions:
- Shot 4 (Leo): Positioned on RIGHT of frame, looking SCREEN-LEFT.
- Shot 5 (Maya): Positioned on LEFT of frame, looking SCREEN-RIGHT.

[180° Rule Guide ↗](#)



2. Veo 3.1 Native Lip-Sync Dialogue Syntax

- Put spoken words in single quotes ('...') right after vocal tone:
- "Leo speaks in a warm, grounded baritone voice: 'Rough night with the blueprints?'"
- Keep dialogue to 8–12 words per 6–8s clip (~2 words/sec).

[Dialogue Prompts ↗](#)



3. Expressive Voiceover (`gemini-3.8-flash-tts`)

- For narrator taglines or cross-platform dubbing, use gemini-3.8-flash-tts with expressive voices (Kore, Charon, Aoede, Puck, Fenrir).
- Supports affective tags: [sigh], [short pause].

[TTS Prompt 5.3 ↗](#)



4. Custom 30s Commercial Score (`lyria-3`)

- Prompt Lyria 3 for a 3-part dynamic arc: sparse felt piano (0–8s) -> warm acoustic guitar on café chime (9–20s) -> uplifting strings crescendo (21–30s) in 48kHz stereo.

[Lyria 3 Prompt ↗](#)



Golden Rule for Lip-Sync: Never exceed 12–14 spoken words in an 8-second clip so the character's cadence feels natural and unhurried.

Live Lab #5: Directing Leo & Maya's Café Counter Conversation

Run Shot 4 (Over-the-Shoulder on Leo) and Shot 5 (Reverse Close-Up on Maya) with synchronized spoken dialogue.



Shot 4: Leo Speaks (Looking Screen-Left)

Over-the-shoulder medium shot from behind Maya's ochre shoulder on the left, focusing on Leo on the right looking screen-left with a warm smile. Leo speaks in a warm baritone: 'Rough night with the blueprints? Start with this—the lines always follow.'



Shot 5: Maya Replies (Looking Screen-Right)

Reverse-angle medium close-up of Maya on the left looking screen-right. She wraps both hands around the terracotta SOLIS cup, inhales the steam, smiles, and replies softly: 'You just saved the whole skyline, Leo.'

Copy-Paste Prompt 5.2 & 5.3 – Maya's Reverse Shot + Gemini 3.8 Flash TTS Tagline

[Copy Stage 5 Prompts ↗](#)

[SHOT 5 - VEO 3.1]: Reverse-angle medium close-up of Maya, a 29-year-old Latina architect with warm olive skin, round tortoiseshell glasses, and ochre knit cardigan on the left of the frame, looking screen-right. She wraps both hands around the terracotta SOLIS cup, smiles, and replies softly: 'You just saved the whole skyline, Leo.' Warm golden key light, 50mm. [VOICEOVER - gemini-3.8-flash-tts (Voice: Kore)]: "[sigh] Every bold idea starts before the sun rises. [short pause] Solis. Awaken the craft."



Verify Across Shots 4 & 5: Leo looks left -> Maya looks right -> The terracotta SOLIS cup sits on the oak counter between them.

Finishing the Commercial with `Extend`, `Jump To` & J/L Audio Cuts

Stitch your 6 shots in Scenebuilder, lengthen emotional reactions, and bridge Maya back to her sunlit studio.



1. Scenebuilder `Extend` (Lengthen Reaction Beats)

- Select the end of Shot 5 in Scenebuilder and click 'Extend'.
- Prompt: 'Continue seamlessly as Maya takes her first slow sip from the terracotta SOLIS cup; her eyes widen with sudden inspiration.'

[Prompt 6.1 ↗](#)



2. Scenebuilder `Jump To` (Scene Match-Cut Finale)

- From the end of Shot 5, click 'Jump To' (or use Frames to Video) for Shot 6.
- Transitions Maya and the SOLIS cup directly into golden sunrise at her studio desk as she sketches the bridge arch.

[Prompt 6.2 ↗](#)



3. The J-Cut / L-Cut Pro Editing Secret

- Never cut audio and video on the exact same millisecond.
- Let the last 0.5s of Leo's line ('the lines always follow...') trail over the visual cut to Shot 6 as Maya's pencil touches the paper!

[Editing Checklist ↗](#)



Final Output: A cohesive 30-second commercial with locked character faces, consistent product branding, and two-way dialogue!

Build Your Own Brand Story: Resources & Bonus Industry Templates

Clone the workshop repository to access all Stage 0–6 prompts, two bonus commercial packs, and the web companion.



GitHub Repository & Interactive Web Portal

- Complete Facilitator Playbook
- Student Incremental Workbook
- Interactive Copy-Paste Web App (docs/index.html)
- Universal Prompt Templates

[Open GitHub Repo ↗](#)



3 Ready-to-Run Commercial Story Packs

- Pack 1: Solis Artisan Coffee (Architect + Barista)
- Pack 2: NovaPay Fintech (Florist + Groom in Rainstorm)
- Pack 3: Kuntur Outdoor Gear (Photographer + Andean Guide)

[Master Prompt Library ↗](#)



Launch Google Flow & Google AI Studio

- Google Flow Workspace: labs.google/fx/tools/flow
- Enterprise Flow: flow.cloud.google.com
- Google AI Studio: aistudio.google.com

[Launch Google Flow ↗](#)



Star & Fork the Workshop Repository: <https://github.com/AllInVaders/google-flow-storytelling-workshop>